

Ἀλέξης ὁ κωμικός

Alexis the Comic Poet on Servants, Masters, and the Symposium

eul_aid: ivq

Period: Ἑλληνιστική Hellenistic

Dialect: Ἀττική Attic (com, frg)

Domain: Κωμωδία Comedy

Format: Ἑμμετρος Verse

Alexis was a comic playwright who lived and worked in ancient Greece during the 4th and early 3rd centuries BCE. He was born in the city of Thurii in southern Italy but built his career in Athens. According to ancient sources, he was possibly the uncle of the famous playwright Menander, though this family connection is uncertain. He was said to have lived an exceptionally long life and written hundreds of plays, bridging the transition from Middle Comedy to New Comedy.

His output was enormous, with ancient records crediting him with well over two hundred comedies. None of his plays survive complete today; we know them only through fragments quoted by later writers. These fragments come from many known titles, such as Aesop, The Tarentines, and The Parasite. The surviving pieces show a focus on social types, domestic situations, and witty dialogue.

Modern scholars see Alexis as a crucial figure for understanding the evolution of Greek comedy. His long career places him at the shift from the more politically oriented Old Comedy toward the comedy of manners and character that defined New Comedy. The fragments of his work provide vital evidence for the development of stock characters, like the parasite and the cook, which became central to later comedy. His elegant style and realistic characters influenced the tradition that led to Menander and, eventually, to Roman comedy.

Works (3)

- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Δούλων καὶ Δεσποτῶν · Fragments on Servants and Masters · 11 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα Συμποτικὰ Ἀλεξίδος · Sympotic Fragments of Alexis · 986 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα Συμποτικὰ Ἀλεξίδου · Sympotic Fragments of Alexis · 1068 passages